Early on October 29 morning, clad in a beige shirt sporting his party's election symbol, the lantern, Tejashwi Yadav boards a waiting VT-JSF helicopter at Patna airport en route to addressing seven rallies that day, including one in Samastipur. The de facto chief of the Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) and chief ministerial candidate of the Opposition Mahagathbandhan alliance is racing against time and geography to reach as many voters as possible. His rallies are not assemblies but dense, kinetic gatherings of young voters waving smartphones like torches of affirmation. It is no different in Samastipur. Near the stage, young men in the party's green colours jostle for space, phones raised high, eager to capture a breathless fragment of their leader.

Tejashwi's speeches, often extempore, deftly weave unemployment, migration and dignity into a single emotional narrative. The RJD's campaign anthem—*'Bihar badalne wala hai, sarkar badalne wali hai* (Bihar is going to change, the government is going to change)'—encapsulates a spirit of renewal. In his idioms, Tejashwi has moved from his father Lalu's grammar of social justice to one of economic aspiration. *"Naukri milegi pakka, bhrashtachar, berozgaari ko karenge* out, *aur rishwatkhori ko karenge* clean-bowled," he tells the crowd, promising jobs, an end to corruption and unemployment, and a 'clean bowling' of graft.

Tejashwi has learnt the rhythms of oratory, the mix of grievous hurt, humour and warmth Lalu had mastered. But his tone is less mocking

The 35-year-old Tejashwi has got the rhythms of oratory down pat—that mix of grievous hurt, humour and warmth his father mastered all those decades ago. But his tone is less mocking, more conciliatory. The previous day, he had addressed six public meetings, criss-crossing Saran, from Manjhi's baked plains to Amnaur's surging crowds. In the days ahead, his daily tally of rallies may touch double digits. While Rahul



Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH

THE ELECTORAL ROLLERCOASTER

Feb. 2000*

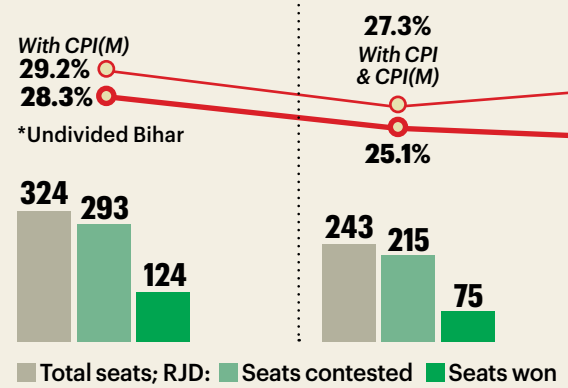
Forms government

Nitish Kumar invited to form government, but resigns within a week. Rabri Devi sworn in as CM with Congress and other parties' support, on condition that RJD would back the creation of Jharkhand that year

Feb. 2005

The end begins

Hung assembly; no party could form the government; the House was dissolved



Graphic by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY